

The Lighthouse at Marrow Point

Every evening, just before the sky turned the colour of cold tea, Ada climbed the one hundred and twelve steps of the lighthouse at Marrow Point. She counted them out of habit, not need. The steps had not changed in forty years, and neither, she suspected, had she.

The lamp was older than the town. It had been shipped over in pieces, bolted together by men whose names were now only scratches on the brass. Ada polished the lens each morning with a cloth her mother had used, and each morning the glass gave back her face, stretched and curious.

Chapter Two

The first boat that did not come was the Kestrel. Ada watched for its green lantern until the tide turned and the wind carried the smell of rain up from the rocks. She logged the hour, the weather, and the absence, because absence was still something that could be written down.

In the morning the harbour master rowed out with news. The Kestrel had put in at Salt Haven instead, its captain spooked by a fog that Ada had not seen from the tower. She wrote that down as well. It was the first time the sea had kept a secret from her.

Chapter Three

Winter arrived with the patience of something that knows it will be staying. Ada wrapped the pipes, stacked the coal, and taught herself to read the weather from the way gulls sat on the railings. When they faced the land, she lit the lamp early.

On the longest night she found a boy on the steps, soaked and shivering, who said he had followed the light. She did not ask from where. She gave him soup, a blanket, and the job of counting the steps, which he got wrong three times before breakfast.

Chapter Four

By spring the boy could polish the lens without leaving a streak, and Ada had stopped counting steps altogether. The Kestrel came back with a new green lantern. The town stayed small. The lighthouse, as lighthouses do, kept turning its one bright thought over and over toward the dark.